

ExpenseTracker — User & Admin Manual

Version: 1.0 • Platform: Web (React client + Express API)

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This manual is designed for end users and operators. It's formatted for GitHub viewing and ready for export to PDF.

1. Project Overview

ExpenseTracker helps you record spending, categorize expenses, track subscriptions, set financial goals, generate reports, analyze trends, and capture receipts with OCR.

Key modules:

- Authentication & Profile
- Expenses & Categories
- Subscriptions
- Goals
- Reports
- Analytics (trends, forecasts, anomalies, recommendations)
- Receipts OCR (PDF/images)
- Bank Connections (Salt Edge)

2. Quick Start

Prerequisites:

- Node.js 18+
- MongoDB (local or Atlas)

Setup:

1. Clone the repo
2. Install server and client dependencies
3. Configure environment variables
4. Start API (<http://localhost:5000> (<http://localhost:5000>)) and client (<http://localhost:3000> (<http://localhost:3000>))

See the main README for commands and env keys.

3. Sign in, Profile, and Security

- Register with email/password, or use Google sign-in when enabled
- Login persists a JWT token; protected pages require auth
- Update profile info and password from Profile page

- Forgotten password: request a reset link via email, then set a new password

Security tips:

- Log out on shared devices
- Use a strong password and enable 2FA on your email

4. Expense Management

4.1 Create an expense

1. Go to Expenses
2. Click Add Expense
3. Enter amount, date, merchant, category, notes
4. Optionally upload a receipt (PDF/JPEG/PNG)
5. Save — it appears in the list

Screenshot: screenshot/add Expense.PNG

4.2 Edit or delete

- In the expense list, use Edit to modify fields, or Delete to remove permanently

4.3 Filter, search, sort

- Filter by date range, category, amount range
- Search by merchant/notes
- Sort by date or amount

4.4 Attach receipts (OCR)

- Upload a receipt when creating or editing
- The server scans for malicious content, extracts text, and auto-suggests amount/date/merchant
- Review extracted fields before saving

5. Categories

- Navigate to Categories
- Create, rename, or delete categories (per-user uniqueness enforced)

Screenshot: screenshot/Categorie.PNG

6. Subscriptions

- Track recurring charges (e.g., streaming services)
- Add subscription with amount, billing cycle, start date, and optional reminders

Screenshot: screenshot/Subscription.PNG

7. Goals

- Define monthly or custom goals (e.g., cap dining at \$200)
- Monitor progress and adjust as needed

Screenshot: screenshot/Fiancial Goals.PNG

8. Reports

- Generate summaries for periods (weekly/monthly/custom)
- Export or view detailed breakdowns

Screenshot: screenshot/Reports.PNG

9. Analytics

- Trends: visualize monthly totals
- Forecasts: projected spend for upcoming months
- Anomalies: detect unusual spikes
- Recommendations: personalized saving tips

Screenshot: screenshot/Analytics.PNG

10. Bank Connections (Salt Edge)

- Start a connect session to link your bank
- After successful linking, fetch transactions and review imported entries
- Note: availability depends on your region and Salt Edge credentials

11. Mobile & Responsiveness

- UI adapts to phones and tablets; navbar hides on auth/reset pages

12. Troubleshooting

- Can't login: check email/password or reset password
- 401 errors: login again; token may be expired
- No charts: ensure there is data for the selected period
- OCR failed: re-upload a clear image or PDF; verify API URL and PUBLIC_BASE_URL
- Broken images: ensure the API serves /uploads and your client points to the correct base URL

13. FAQ

- Where are my files stored? Receipts are stored on the server in uploads/receipts and served via /uploads
- Can I change currency? Not yet; see Roadmap
- Is my bank password stored? Bank linking uses Salt Edge; credentials are not stored by this app

14. Support

- Issues: create a GitHub issue or contact the maintainer
- Email: mohamedahmar06@gmail.com (<mailto:mohamedahmar06@gmail.com>)

15. Appendix — API Cheat Sheet

Base URL: <http://localhost:5000/api> (<http://localhost:5000/api>).

Auth

- POST /users/register
- POST /users/login
- GET /users/profile (Bearer token required)

Expenses

- GET /expenses?
startDate&endDate&category&categories=a,b&minAmount&maxAmount&hasReceipt&search&page&limit&sortBy=field:asc|desc
- POST /expenses
- PUT /expenses/:id
- DELETE /expenses/:id
- GET /expenses/stats
- GET /expenses/chart?period=monthly|category&startDate&endDate

Receipts

- POST /receipts (multipart/form-data)

Analytics

- GET /analytics/trends?period=month&limit=6
- GET /analytics/forecasts?months=3
- GET /analytics/anomalies
- GET /analytics/recommendations

Categories, Reports, Goals, Subscriptions have standard CRUD endpoints under /api.